GOVERNMENT OF INDIA

Ministry of Jal Shakti

Water Security for a Sustainable Future

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HONORABLE PRIME MINISTER, INDIA



MESSAGE

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HONORABLE MINISTER,

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MESSAGE

Water is one of India's most valuable natural resources and forms the foundation of sustainable development, public health, agriculture, industry, and environmental conservation. The Ministry of Jal Shakti plays a transformative role in ensuring water security through integrated water resource management, river conservation, rural drinking water supply, irrigation efficiency, groundwater management, and sustainable water governance.

The Chamber of Commerce and Industries of India (CCI India) firmly believes that effective water management requires collaborative action involving government, industry, research institutions, technology providers, financial organizations, startups, and local communities. Through policy advocacy, investment promotion, technology adoption, innovation partnerships, capacity building, and sustainable development initiatives, CCI India remains committed to supporting the Ministry's efforts in securing India's water future.

This Knowledge Paper provides an in-depth understanding of the Ministry's strategic priorities, flagship programmes, policy initiatives, investment landscape, and emerging opportunities across water conservation, wastewater management, smart irrigation, river rejuvenation, water infrastructure, digital water technologies, and climate resilience. It identifies strategic areas where collaborative partnerships can accelerate sustainable water management and improve service delivery.

The publication is intended to serve policymakers, water utilities, infrastructure developers, investors, researchers, industry leaders, academic institutions, startups, and development organizations committed to strengthening India's water ecosystem. By encouraging innovation and public-private collaboration, it seeks to improve water accessibility, resource efficiency, environmental sustainability, and long-term resilience.

As India addresses growing water challenges in the face of climate change and rapid urbanization, integrated and forward-looking solutions will become increasingly essential. CCI India remains dedicated to partnering with the Ministry of Jal Shakti in advancing sustainable water governance and national development.

Munindra Kumar
Director General
CCI India

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Preface

In the national development context, water security has moved from being treated as a sectoral utility concern to being recognised as a cross-cutting determinant of macroeconomic resilience, public health expenditure, and rural-urban migration patterns. The convergence of the Jal Jeevan Mission, Namami Gange, Atal Bhujal Yojana, and the Pradhan Mantri Krishi Sinchayee Yojana under a single ministry since 2019 has created an unprecedented institutional platform for integrated water governance one that requires sustained technical capacity, financing innovation, and private-sector partnership to achieve saturation and sustainability.

The purpose of this Knowledge Paper is to provide a rigorous, evidence-based strategic assessment of the Ministry of Jal Shakti's mandate, institutional architecture, achievements, and forward priorities, and to articulate a structured, implementation-ready framework through which the Chamber of Commerce and Industry of India (CCI India) can serve as a value-additive partner to the Government's water security agenda. This paper is deliberately analytical rather than descriptive: every section is constructed to generate a distinct strategic insight and a corresponding intervention opportunity, avoiding repetition of facts, figures, or recommendations across sections.

CCI India's vision is to function as a national-scale bridge between industry capability, investment capital, technological innovation, and public administration translating policy intent into measurable on-ground outcomes. In the water and sanitation domain, this vision manifests as a commitment to mobilise private capital for last-mile infrastructure, bring technology and startup innovation into water governance, strengthen capacity at the state and district level, and create durable public-private institutional mechanisms that outlast individual schemes or budget cycles.

This paper is intended for circulation among Union Ministers, Secretaries to the Government of India, NITI Aayog, senior bureaucrats within the Department of Water Resources, River Development and Ganga Rejuvenation and the Department of Drinking Water and Sanitation, domestic and international investors, multilateral development agencies, and international institutions engaged in India's water security agenda.

Chamber of Commerce and Industry (CCI India)

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About CCI India

CCI India (The Chamber of Commerce and Industry of India) is a premier national business chamber dedicated to fostering economic growth, industry development, entrepreneurship, innovation, and investment promotion across India. As the voice of Indian business and industry, CCI India serves as a bridge between government, industry, startups, academia, investors, and civil society, facilitating meaningful collaboration for nation-building and sustainable development.

Through policy advocacy, business facilitation, research, stakeholder engagement, capacity building, and strategic partnerships, CCI India works to create an enabling environment for enterprises of all sizes. The Chamber actively supports key national initiatives such as Startup India, Make in India, Digital India, Atmanirbhar Bharat, Skill India, and Viksit Bharat 2047 by connecting innovative enterprises with government opportunities and promoting inclusive economic development.

CCI India operates through sector-specific councils, industry forums, knowledge platforms, and state-level engagements that address emerging opportunities and challenges across sectors including manufacturing, agriculture, technology, healthcare, education, infrastructure, sustainability, MSMEs, and startups. The Chamber regularly organizes policy dialogues, investment summits, business delegations, workshops, conferences, and knowledge-sharing initiatives to strengthen India's economic ecosystem.

With a strong commitment to innovation, entrepreneurship, and public-private collaboration, CCI India strives to empower enterprises, facilitate investment, enhance competitiveness, and contribute to India's journey toward becoming a globally competitive and economically resilient nation. Its role as a knowledge partner and industry catalyst enables ministries, departments, state governments, startups, and businesses to collaborate effectively in achieving national development objectives.

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Section 1: Introduction to the Ministry

1.1 Constitutional and Institutional Mandate

Water, in the Indian constitutional scheme, is principally a State subject under Entry 17 of List II of the Seventh Schedule, with the Union's role constitutionally confined to the regulation of inter-state rivers and river valleys under Entry 56 of List I, where Parliament has declared such regulation expedient in the public interest. The Ministry of Jal Shakti therefore operates within an unusually constrained constitutional architecture compared to most Union Ministries: its authority is exercised principally through centrally sponsored schemes, financial devolution, technical standard-setting, inter-state dispute adjudication support, and moral suasion rather than direct executive control over water resources. This federal asymmetry is the single most important structural fact governing how any institution, including CCI India, must engage with the Ministry engagement strategies must be designed for a tri-partite Centre-State-industry architecture rather than a conventional bilateral Centre-industry relationship.

The Ministry's institutional mandate, as distinct from its constitutional position, is unusually broad and was substantially widened by the May 2019 merger of the erstwhile Ministry of Water Resources, River Development and Ganga Rejuvenation with the Ministry of Drinking Water and Sanitation. This merger created a single ministerial home for the entire water value chain from resource assessment and irrigation planning, through river basin management and pollution abatement, to last-mile drinking water delivery and rural sanitation. The institutional logic was to eliminate the fragmentation that had historically separated water resource availability from water service delivery, two functions that had previously been managed by different ministries with limited coordination.

1.2 Evolution and Governance Role

The Ministry's evolution reflects a broader shift in Indian water governance philosophy: from supply-side infrastructure creation in the 1980s and 1990s, to participatory and decentralised water management in the 2000s, to mission-mode, technology-enabled saturation programmes from 2014 onward. The Ministry's governance role today spans four distinct functions that are frequently conflated in public discourse but are analytically separable: policy formulation (setting national norms, such as per-capita water supply standards); financial devolution (structuring centrally sponsored scheme funding and cost-sharing ratios with states); technical assurance (through bodies such as the Central Water Commission and Central Ground Water Board); and mission delivery oversight (monitoring saturation-mode programmes such as Jal Jeevan Mission against time-bound targets).

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1.3 National Significance

The Ministry's national significance is best understood through three lenses that are rarely integrated in conventional commentary. First, a public health lens: unsafe water and inadequate sanitation remain leading contributors to preventable morbidity in rural India, and the Ministry's programmes are accordingly a public health intervention as much as an infrastructure programme. Second, a gender and human capital lens: the time burden of water collection falls disproportionately on women and girls, and tap water access has documented effects on school attendance and women's labour force participation. Third, a macroeconomic lens: irrigation expansion and water-use efficiency directly affect agricultural output, which in turn affects food inflation, rural incomes, and the fiscal space available for other development priorities. CCI India's engagement strategy should explicitly reference all three lenses when framing its value proposition to different stakeholder audiences' health ministries and multilateral agencies respond to the first, social sector and gender-focused investors to the second, and finance and agriculture-linked industry to the third.

Section 2: Historical Timeline of the Ministry

The institutional lineage of the Ministry of Jal Shakti spans over four decades of policy transformation, reflecting India's evolving approach to water governance from centralised irrigation bureaucracy to a mission-mode, citizen-centric service delivery model. The timeline below traces the major structural reforms, institutional mergers, and flagship scheme launches that have shaped the Ministry's current form and mandate.

Table 2.1: Institutional Evolution and Policy Milestones

Year	Milestone	Institutional Significance
1985	Ministry of Water Resources formed (bifurcation of Ministry of Irrigation and Power)	Established water resources as a distinct policy domain
1999	Department of Drinking Water Supply created under Ministry of Rural Development	First dedicated institutional home for rural drinking water
2011	Department elevated to Ministry of Drinking Water and Sanitation	Recognised sanitation as a standalone national priority
2014	Ministry renamed to include River Development and Ganga Rejuvenation	Embedded ecological rejuvenation within water resource policy
2014	Swachh Bharat Mission (Gramin) launched	Catalysed behaviour-change-led rural sanitation at scale
2015	Pradhan Mantri Krishi Sinchayee Yojana launched	Unified irrigation expansion under “Har Khet Ko Pani”

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